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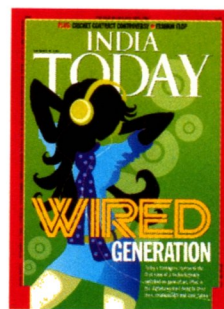
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It is fascinating to see the way that modern day psychologists are labelling groups of people. It used to be entire generations, as in the baby boomers, but nowadays the grouping is getting narrower with the nomenclature combining two existing segments. 'Adolescents' or 'Kidults' are used for adults who act much younger than their age while even children are being broken up into sections. 'Tweens' was a phrase coined for those between the ages of eight and 12 as they represented a well-defined consumer subdivision. We may have to find a new label to fit the kids/teenagers/semi-adults who are the target of our cover story this issue: adolescents between the ages of six and 17 who are so obsessed with looking good and dressing in designer outfits that they have become adults well before their time. The action for today's kids has shifted from art or drama workshops to salons and spas and, shockingly enough, under the cosmetic surgeon's knife.

From manicures to pedicures, facials to body massages, kids in the age group of six to 15 are thronging specialised kids salons that have sprung up in big cities. And if they aren't applying blush-on to their faces, six to 12-year-olds are running on the treadmill to make sure the burgers don't show on their waist. Mothers are also dragging their 10 and 11-year-old daughters to laser clinics to rid them of unwanted hair. The fascination with looking good gets more serious with teenagers choosing surgery to enhance their appearance. As shocking as it may sound, 16-year-olds have also gone under the knife for breast implants. Psychiatrists we interviewed point out that a lot of kids today would prefer to be actors and models rather than doctors and lawyers as they can be part of the glamour brigade, make money, wear good clothes and be on the cover of magazines.

The overall market size for kids (12-16 years) in urban India is close to Rs 15,000 crore and growing at 25-30 per cent a year. Marketers are realising that what's good for adults is equally good for the children. In fact, children no longer want to be treated as children. That is a dangerous obsession. Adolescence is a crucial phase where it is natural to become aware of looks but self-obsession can lead to psychological distortions. Children emotionally concerned with looks create roadblocks to a natural evolution of their personality. Irrational dieting leads to anorexia and also induces low self-esteem. School authorities admit that the obsession with looking good affects academic and extracurricular growth. Our cover story examines the trend and its impact. Says Associate Editor Malini Bhupta, who anchored the story: "Childhood is clearly in fast forward mode and parents seem to have no qualms putting an expiry date on adolescence." Affluence can sometimes be a curse too as is evident from our cover story. It is taking away the best part of our children's life: their innocence.



Our Nov 2006 cover

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)